HAMASPIK LEOVDEI HASHEM

# When Greatness Falls: Arrogance in Tanakh

**Given Monday 27 April 2026** · HaMaspik LeOvdei HaShem, Chapter 7 Part 2

Sefer: HaMaspik L'Ovdei Hashem (Kifayat al-Abidin) — Rabbi Avraham ben HaRambam Chapter: Perek 7 (ענוה — Humility) — Part 2 Edition: Feldheim Theme: Training Method 2 (continued) — what happens when humility is missing

---

## Recap: Chapter 7 Part 1

- Chapter 1: Two paths — the Tzaddik (basics) and the Chasid (beyond)
- Chapter 2: All middot are interrelated
- Chapter 3: Purity of motive — four levels
- Chapter 4: Compassion — first of the 13 Attributes. When in doubt → mercy
- Chapter 5: Generosity — four kinds: money, influence, intellect, faith
- Chapter 6: Calmness — intellect over emotion. Anger + arrogance linked; patience + humility linked. Sometimes anger is appropriate for spiritual matters.
- Chapter 7 Part 1: Humility defined — internal vs. external, vis-à-vis God and humans. Humility = recognizing yourself exactly as you are, not exaggerating up or down. NOT self-debasement.

Three methods of training:

1. Personal/experiential — reflecting on past arrogance, surrounding oneself with humble people
2. Through the Torah — stories of humble vs. arrogant figures + mitzvot designed to cultivate humility
3. Philosophical analysis — to come in a future class

Last class covered: Positive examples (Avraham — "I am dust and ash"; Yaakov; Elisha) + the negative example of Nadav and Avihu — root failure was not taking counsel from Moshe despite their lofty status.

---

## This Week's Theme

This class continues the second method of training — but now turning to the warning side: people in Tanakh who lost humility and what it cost them.

Two crucial framings throughout:

1. These figures were not simple troublemakers. Rabbi Avraham emphasizes again and again that they were genuinely great, prominent, even prophetic people. The whole point is that even greatness offers no protection.
2. These stories are not just history — they function as mirrors. Rabbi Avraham wants us to see ourselves in them.

---

## In the Torah: Korach, Datan & Aviram

Don't underestimate who they were.

Rabbi Avraham insists we correct a common misconception. Korach was not a simple man with an inflated ego. He was a great person — and Datan and Aviram, though not on Korach's level, were also significant figures.

### Evidence for Korach's Greatness

- The 250 men who joined him are described as נשיאי עדה קריאי מועד אנשי שם — princes of the community, men of name. Prominent leaders accepted his argument.
- When Moshe proposed the test of the firepans, Korach accepted without hesitation. A simple challenger would not be entertained by Moshe — the test shows Moshe took the threat seriously.

  Moshe fell on his face. Rashi: exhaustion at yet another machloket. Rabbi Avraham: ויפול על פניו — genuine fear, because the threat was real.
- Moshe had to pray that Hashem not accept their offering. If they were ordinary sinners, no such prayer would be needed.
- Even after they perished, Hashem honored their firepans by incorporating them into the Mishkan: כי הקריבו לפני ה' ויקדשו
- The people complained: אתם המיתם את עם ה' — they mourned Korach as a prominent figure.

### Datan and Aviram — A Surprising Reading

We're accustomed (from Rashi) to seeing Datan and Aviram as perennial troublemakers. Rabbi Avraham reads them differently.

- The verse calls them אנשים — and in Tanakh, אנשים often denotes prominent people (as in שלח לך אנשים, the meraglim).
- They were people of standing. Why called resha'im?

1. Relative to Moshe and Korach, they were on a lower spiritual level — average rather than wicked
2. They were corrupting themselves by joining the rebellion

### The Religious Veneer — Critical Point

Korach's rebellion had a religious face:

רב לכם כי כל העדה כלם קדשים ובתוכם ה' ומדוע תתנשאו על קהל ה'

Moshe himself said: כי משאת נפשם היתה כהונה — they wanted priesthood, a holy ambition. Even arrogance dressed as religious zeal is still arrogance.

Datan and Aviram had a different flavour — pure jealousy and resentment of Moshe's authority (המעט כי העליתנו מארץ מצרים כי תשתרר). Less religiously framed, more about kavod — but the same root.

---

## In the Nevi'im: Shaul HaMelech

Rabbi Avraham (and the Rambam) hold that Shaul was not only a king but also a prophet — בחיר השם, chosen by Hashem.

Three failures, all rooted in arrogance and pursuit of human approval:

### Failure 1 — The War with Amalek

- Commanded to wipe out Amalek completely. He didn't — spared Agag and the choice animals.
- Why? פחדו מבני אדם פן ישביתו את שלטונו הגשמי — he feared the people would undermine his sovereignty.
- His confession: יראתי את העם ואשמע בקולם — I feared the people and listened to them.
- Even after confessing, he asked Shmuel: כבדני נא נגד זקני עמי — please honor me before the elders. Even at the moment of repentance, his concern was still public perception.

### Failure 2 — Jealousy of David

- After David killed Goliath, the women sang הכה שאול באלפיו ודוד ברבבותיו
- From that day: ויהי שאול עוין את דוד — the unusual word עוין means he analyzed David negatively, constantly looking to find fault.
- Root: I am the king, I must be on top, everyone must recognize this. Pure ga'avah.

### Failure 3 — The Massacre at Nov

- Doeg told Shaul that the priests of Nov had given David bread.
- Shaul ordered the entire city slaughtered — men, women, children, animals.
- The bitter irony: What Shaul failed to do to Amalek, he did to a city of priests.

Connection to this Shabbat's Pirkei Avot: הקנאה התאוה והכבוד מוציאין את האדם מן העולם — jealousy, desire, and honor remove a person from the world.

---

## Doeg HaAdomi

Doeg was no ignoramus. He was a Talmid Chacham. The verse describes him as נעצר לפני ה' — constantly serving Hashem in the Mishkan.

- His failure: wanting to find favor in Shaul's eyes.
- He reported on the priests of Nov. When Shaul's own servants refused to carry out the slaughter, Doeg himself struck down the Kohen Gadol.
- Rambam in Peirush HaMishnayot cites Doeg as the example of אל תתודע לרשות — do not become overly familiar with the authorities.

Three punishments (from Tehillim, derived in Sanhedrin):

אין לו חלק לעולם הבא — no portion in the world to come

- His Torah teachings would not be cited (יחתך)
- His descendants would not become Talmidei Chachamim (ושרשך מארץ חיים)

A Talmid Chacham who lost everything — Olam HaBa, his learning legacy, his line — all because he chased the king's favor.

---

## Achitofel

David's counselor, one of the great minds of his generation. Chazal describe him as enormously wise.

- His failure: wanting to find favor in Avshalom's eyes during the rebellion. He calculated Avshalom would win and switched allegiance.
- He gave Avshalom two pieces of advice. The military advice was sound — Avshalom didn't take it.

- At that moment Achitofel realized Avshalom would fail and David would return.

Why he killed himself (Radak):

1. He knew David would have him executed for rebellion (mored b'malchut)
2. An executed rebel's property was forfeit to the king
3. By killing himself first, he saved his estate for his children

Result: Hanged himself, lost his portion in the world to come (Mishna in Sanhedrin), died disgracefully — all to chase favor with a son who would never sit on the throne.

---

## Avshalom

Surprisingly elevated terms — Chazal say Avshalom was a permanent Nazir (אבשלום נזיר עולם). Even David himself was deceived when Avshalom asked permission to go to Hevron to fulfill a vow: ...כי נדר נדר עבדך ועבדתי את ה'

- Of course this was a ruse — Avshalom was going to Hevron to consolidate the rebellion.
- But David, who knew his son well, was fooled — which shows Avshalom was not a transparent villain. He had real religious credentials.
- Downfall: תאוות השררה והתנשאות — desire for power and elevation.

---

## Adoniyah ben Haggit

- Another son of David, attempted to claim the throne ahead of Shlomo.
- Attracted serious figures — Yoav and Evyatar HaKohen joined him.
- This is the famous opening of Sefer Melachim — source of the royal anointing ceremony.
- Prominent enough to attract great supporters — yet his hunger for power, despite David's clear designation of Shlomo, brought his downfall.

---

## Yoav ben Tzeruyah

David's general — a great military leader.

### Establishing Yoav's Real Greatness

- Before the war with Ammon: חזק ונתחזק בעד עמנו ובעד ערי אלוהינו והשם יעשה הטוב בעיניו — a man of bitachon.
- Listened to the wise woman of Avel who pleaded not to destroy the city for one rebel (Sheva ben Bichri). One Midrash identifies the wise woman as Serach bat Asher.
- Protested David's census: למה יבקש זאת אדוני למה יהיה אשמה לישראל

### Yet Yoav Came to Murder Twice

1. Avner ben Ner — After Avner made peace with David, Yoav killed him. Reasons: revenge for his brother Asael's death + suspicion Avner would replace him.
2. Amasa ben Yeter — After David replaced Yoav with Amasa as general, Yoav killed him.

Both times by deception — calling them over to "talk," then striking.

The verse in Mishpatim:

וכי יזיד איש על רעהו להרגו בערמה מעם מזבחי תקחנו למות

Rabbi Avraham reads this as a hint to Yoav — who indeed fled to the altar and was taken from it to be executed by Benayahu on Shlomo's orders. We do not find this happening to anyone else.

Shlomo's revealing words: השב פגע בשני אנשים צדיקים וטובים ממנו — the phrase ממנו ("better than him") implies Yoav himself was a righteous man — just less so than Avner and Amasa.

---

## Rechavam ben Shlomo

The son of Shlomo — the beginning of the unraveling of the kingdom.

- People came requesting relief from heavy burdens.
- Elders advised compromise. The young men advised: קטני עבה ממתני אבי — my little finger is thicker than my father's loins.
- His refusal caused the rebellion of Yeravam and the splitting of Am Yisrael — the eventual exile of the Aseret HaShevatim.

The pattern played out twice:

- Later, when his reign was reconsolidated and Hashem strengthened him, he again forgot Hakadosh Baruch Hu.
- Shishak of Egypt was sent against him.
- Only when Rechavam and his princes humbled themselves did Hashem relent: ובהכנעו שב ממנו אף ה'
- Arrogance summons punishment; humility relieves it.

---

## Yeravam ben Nevat

Yeravam, whose name has become synonymous with heresy, did not start that way.

- A great man, chosen by Hashem through the prophet Achiyah HaShiloni.
- Chazal say he and Achiyah were the great Chachamim of the generation — his colleagues did not approach his level.
- Hashem promised him: ואותך אקח ומלכת בכל אשר תאוה נפשך... והייתי עמך

What went wrong:

- Once given the kingship, ga'avah took hold.
- Worried that if his subjects went up to Yerushalayim for the regalim, they'd be drawn back to the southern kingdom.
- Rather than trust Hashem, he built the golden calves at Beit El and Dan, instituted alternative festivals, led the nation into avodah zarah.
- The verse traces his thought process: ויאמר ירבעם בלבו עתה תשוב הממלכה לבית דוד — pure political fear, pure jealousy.
- His memory is recorded as a curse. All from ga'avah.

---

## Uziyahu HaMelech

Uziyahu (Azariah) ben Amatzyahu was a good king — the verse explicitly testifies to his righteousness.

His failure was not avodah zarah. It was something subtler:

וכחזקתו גבה לבו עד להשחית

- Entered the Heichal to offer ketoret — the privilege of the Kohanim alone.
- Azariah HaKohen and 80 priests confronted him. He refused to back down.

Parallel to Korach: This too was religiously-framed arrogance — he wanted to serve Hashem with the ketoret. But his sense that "I am the king, this should be mine too" was the same root.

Result: Struck with tzaraat on the spot, lost his kingship, his son Yotam took the throne while still young.

---

## Chizkiyahu HaMelech — The Most Striking Case

Rabbi Avraham saves the most surprising case for last.

- Chizkiyahu was an exceptional king — removed avodah zarah, restored Torah, profoundly righteous.
- Yet ga'avah attached even to him.

The unique element: Chizkiyahu's arrogance did not lead him to commit any specific sin. No murder, no avodah zarah, no rebellion.

ולא נזכר שהגאווה הזאת הביאתו לידי מרד נגד ה' אלא על עצם הגאווה בא הקצף

The wrath came on the arrogance itself.

- Chizkiyahu was deathly ill, prayed, was healed with a sign.

  ולא כגמול עליו השיב חזקיהו כי גבה לבו — he did not respond with the gratitude expected, because his heart became elevated.

- When he humbled himself again, the wrath was held back.

The chilling lesson: For the truly close servants of Hashem, ga'avah itself — even without external sin — is enough to summon divine displeasure. Arrogance is itself a form of rebellion (חטא ומרד), as the verse says: תועבת ה' כל גבה לב — every arrogant heart is an abomination to Hashem.

---

## Statements of the Chachamim

### The Rambam on Pirkei Avot

מאוד מאוד הוי שפל רוח שתקוות אנוש רימה

- The Rambam stresses the doubled מאוד מאוד. Why? Because remembering this single truth — that the body returns to dust — is enough to evoke true humility in any thinking person.
- The root of sin is rarely ignorance. We know what is right. The problem is that we forget. We live on autopilot.
- Simply learning these matters, speaking them out loud, thinking about them — that itself is the avodah. The act of study is the act of remembering.

### The Threefold Teaching: Hashem's Greatness and Humility

The Gemara at the end of Megillah:

כל מקום שאתה מוצא גבורתו של הקדוש ברוך הוא שם אתה מוצא ענוותנותו

Wherever you find the strength of Hakadosh Baruch Hu, there you find His humility. Mentioned three times:

- Torah (Eikev): האל הגדול הגיבור והנורא → followed immediately by עושה משפט יתום ואלמנה ואוהב גר

- Nevi'im (Yeshayah): רם ונשא שוכן עד וקדוש שמו → followed by ואת דכא ושפל רוח
- Ketuvim (Tehillim — the one we read on Shavuot): סולו לרוכב בערבות → followed by אבי יתומים ודיין אלמנות

Hashem's strength is inseparable from His care for the lowly.

### Other Statements

- David in Tehillim: וענוותך תרבני — Your humility makes me great
- Mishna in Avot: תלמידיו של אברהם אבינו עין טובה ונפש שפלה ורוח נמוכה — the students of Avraham have a good eye, a low soul, and a humble spirit. (We will discuss the difference between נפש שפלה and רוח נמוכה next time.)
- Gemara in Pesachim: אוי לה לרבנות שמקברת את בעליה — woe to leadership, for it buries those who hold it.
- Yeshayahu HaNavi outlived four kings (Uziyah, Yotam, Achaz, Chizkiyahu)
- Michah also outlived four kings
- Yosef HaTzadik lived only 110 years — fewer than his brothers — because of his leadership role (Berachot)

Too much authority is dangerous. The crown wears down its bearer.

---

## The Throughline

Across every figure in this shiur, the same pattern repeats with variations:

- Religiously masked arrogance: Korach, Uziyahu
- Straightforward pride: Yeravam, Avshalom
- Fear of losing position: Shaul, Yoav
- Chasing favor with authority: Doeg, Achitofel
- Heart simply elevated for a moment: Chizkiyahu

The remedy in every case is הכנעה — bringing oneself low. Where it was applied (Rechavam after Shishak; Chizkiyahu in his moment of recognition), the wrath was held back.

The reason this chapter comes through stories rather than philosophy is precisely the Rambam's point: we don't fall because we don't know. We fall because we forget. The stories are designed to be remembered.

---

## Coming Up Next

- Next class: Continuation of Chapter 7 — the mitzvot in the Torah designed to cultivate humility. The standout example is the king, who is given an extraordinary number of mitzvot precisely to keep his ga'avah in check.
- After that: The third method of training — philosophical analysis.

---

*B'Ezrat Hashem*

---

Watch or listen to this shiur: youtu.be/51LkNgjxDmU · More shiurim: rabbikada.com